FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Sports lovers across the globe are agog as the Olympics return to France's beautiful capital after precisely one century. This promises to be a unique Olympics, with the opening ceremony at the Gardens of Trocadero, the Eiffel Tower forming part of the backdrop, and the participants sailing down the river Seine. The lucky ones will witness charming events like dressage—think of it as the equestrian equivalent of ballet—against the backdrop of the Palace of Versailles. It will feature India's first-ever participant, Anush Agarwalla. His horse, Sir Caramello Old, will be prancing to "*Jai Ho*"! Will that exuberant victory chant rub off on the whole contingent? We will know soon. This week, we celebrate India's Quest for Gold with a curtain-raiser. After the Tokyo Olympics, India's Olympic ambitions have begun to soar. Tokyo 2020 was a watershed moment. We got our highest-ever tally of seven medals and also marked a distinct change in trajectory—Neeraj Chopra's javelin gold was the first by an Indian in a track and field event.

India's Tokyo contingent was the largest ever: over 120 athletes across disciplines. At 117, the Paris-bound ensemble is actually a tad smaller—it also looks puny compared to the US (592) and China (388). Yet, India boasts a good crop of athletes who are really in the medal hunt; the optimists are counting the final tally in the double digits. You will find all the candidates, veterans as well as fresh arrivals in our gallery of profiles curated and written by Deputy Editor Suhani Singh. It has lavish, exclusive photographs by our Photo Editor, Bandeep Singh, that capture all their outward flair and inner drama. Along with an event calendar, this is your guidebook to help you zero in on everyone with a realisable chance of getting up onto an Olympic podium with the Indian anthem playing.



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Neeraj Chopra leads the order of precedence. When it comes to all-conquering performance, he has been there, done that—and stayed there. He's both the Olympic champion and the World champion. But some of his competitors have breached the 90-metre barrier—his best was only whisperingly close, at 89.94 m. He also came second in the Doha Diamond League in May. But the country lad from Haryana knows how to keep it cool and let it rip on the big day. Next is 'SatChi'—the flamboyant badminton doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, who were World No. 1 in October 2023. In the past two years, the Danish coach Mathias Boe, Olympic silver medallist and husband of actress Taapsee Pannu, has honed their single-gear all-out attack game into a complete demolition system with more range and durability, without slowing them down. Satwik still owns the Guinness record for the fastest hit in badminton, a 565 kmph smash.

Next is our galaxy of female stars from the 'power' games: plenty of grit and guts hold up their potential for glory. Nikhat Zareen, the tough girl from Nizamabad who graces our cover, is not getting kid-glove treatment in Paris despite being a two-time world champion in flyweight/light flyweight (2022, 2023) categories—the boxer is going unseeded and so faces a tough draw. But missing out on Tokyo has only whetted her appetite. Nor has a bronze at Tokyo sated the appetite of fellow pugilist Lovlina Borgohain—a World Championship gold in 2023 proves the Assamese has it in her to go for more. Mirabai Chanu, the silver medalist at Tokyo, has long made pain her best friend. The Meitei weightlifter came out of a career-threatening hip injury to lift well over three times her body weight of 49 kg to qualify again. Among wrestlers, no one would blame Vinesh Phogat for being unable to fully focus on training. The former World No. 1 was kept busy wrestling entities outside the mat, way beyond her weight category. Now, she has changed hers to have a shot at her first Olympic medal, even if the 50 kg draw will be more challenging for her. Last but not least, there's Antim Panghal, 19, the next Haryana wrestling sensation that Vinesh had to make way for in 53 kg.

Among team events, the men's hockey team, which brought in a medal at Tokyo after a gap of 41 years, is in the hunt again—with 11 of that same squad. But our overall medal tally could hinge on another posse. India has 21 shooters lining up for 27 events at Châteauroux in central France, three hours away from all the noise in Paris. In a game of probabilities, the more chances you get, the higher the chances of a medal. The one to watch out for is Sift Kaur Samra, the 22-year-old world record holder from Faridkot whose 'chill' attitude leans towards the Punjabi pop of Diljit Dosanjh and camping in her Scorpio.

It was Antwerp 1920 that hosted the first proper Indian Olympic team. Dorabji Tata was its moving spirit and chief sponsor; he repeated the role in Paris in 1924. Looking back a century later, we count only 35 medals in 24 editions of the Olympics. Official institutional support has been feeble historically. The Modi government's Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) does support around 300 athletes now, but the total outlay for the Paris cycle was Rs 400 crore. That's over three years and across numerous sports. At Paris, India is competing in 16 disciplines out of 45. Compare that to cricket. By some reported estimates, the taxes the BCCI paid in 2022-23 were 10 times that! Training facilities still need to be world-class. Neeraj Chopra trains mainly abroad. So does Nethra Kumanan, the sailor whose dinghy will be on view off the Marseille coast. Bhajan Kaur, an 18-year-old wunderkind, grew up training in a makeshift archery range set up by her farmer-father near their wheat fields in Haryana, reminiscent of shooter Abhinav Bindra, who had to pave his own path to an Olympic gold. Political grandees with little knowledge or interest in sports still monopolise sporting federations. We need the Dorabji Tatas of today if India has to do justice to its human potential. India now boasts 200 billionaires. It's time more stepped up to add to our sporting glory.

When our athletes win, it is against heavy odds. Kudos to them. Meanwhile, we wish them the best of luck.

(Aroon Purie)